

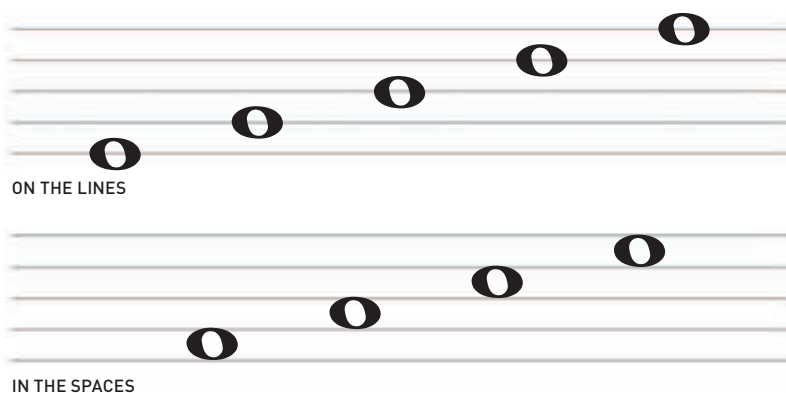
How music works

Understanding how music works – music theory – is a vital part of learning how to read music and play an instrument. To play music, you need to understand its language – notes, pitch, rhythm, and harmony.

WRITING MUSIC

Music is usually written on five parallel lines known as a staff. Notes are placed on the lines, or in the spaces between them. The higher a note is placed, the higher its pitch.

THE FIRST KNOWN MUSIC WAS WRITTEN IN AN ANCIENT LANGUAGE CALLED CUNEIFORM, 3,400 YEARS AGO

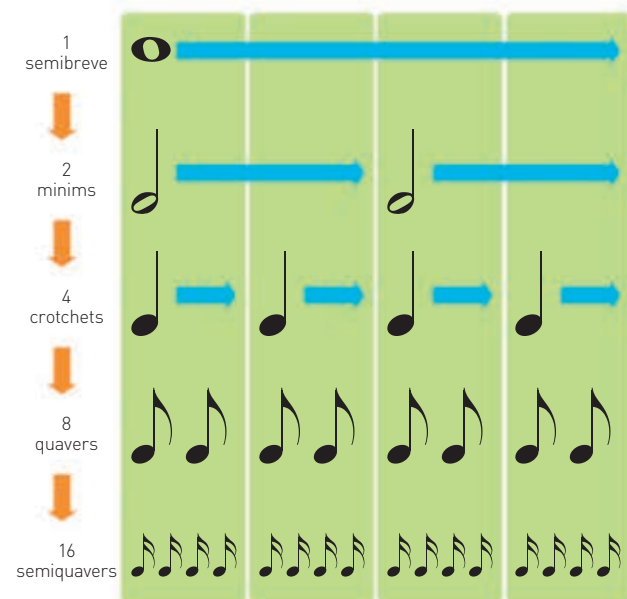


NOTE VALUES

A note value is how long a note lasts for. It is measured in relation to other notes. Shown below – in descending order of length – are the five most common note values: semibreve, minim, crotchet, quaver, and semiquaver.

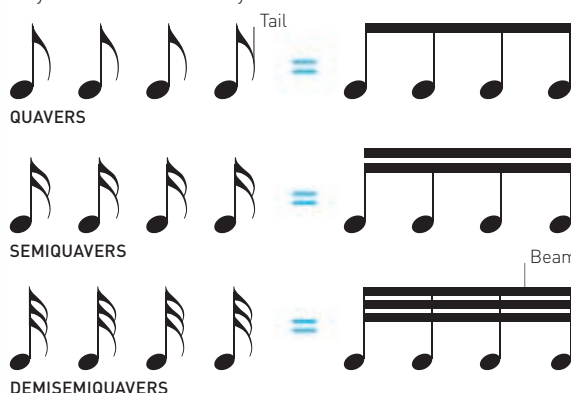
TIME VALUES

The chart below shows how the note values relate to each other. Each column represents one crotchet, so a semibreve lasts as long as four crotchets.



BEAMS

Two or more consecutive quavers can be joined together with a thick line called a beam, which replaces the individual tails. Semiquavers or demisemiquavers can be joined in the same way. Beams make the rhythm easier to read.



TIME SIGNATURES

Time signatures appear at the beginning of a piece of music. The top number indicates the number of beats in a bar, and the bottom number shows the note-value of each beat: 2 = minim, 4 = crotchet, 8 = quaver, and 16 = semiquaver.

$\frac{2}{4}$ Two crotchet beats to the bar

$\frac{4}{4}$ Four crotchet beats to the bar

$\frac{3}{2}$ Three minim beats to the bar

$\frac{9}{8}$ Nine quaver beats to the bar

$\frac{3}{4}$ Three crotchet beats to the bar

$\frac{2}{2}$ Two minim beats to the bar

$\frac{6}{8}$ Six quaver beats to the bar

$\frac{12}{8}$ Twelve quaver beats to the bar

THE PIANO KEYBOARD

Each octave on the piano keyboard has seven white notes – A B C D E F G – and five black notes, grouped in twos and threes. A full-sized keyboard usually has around seven octaves. Its central C is called Middle C.

The black notes occur in twos and threes



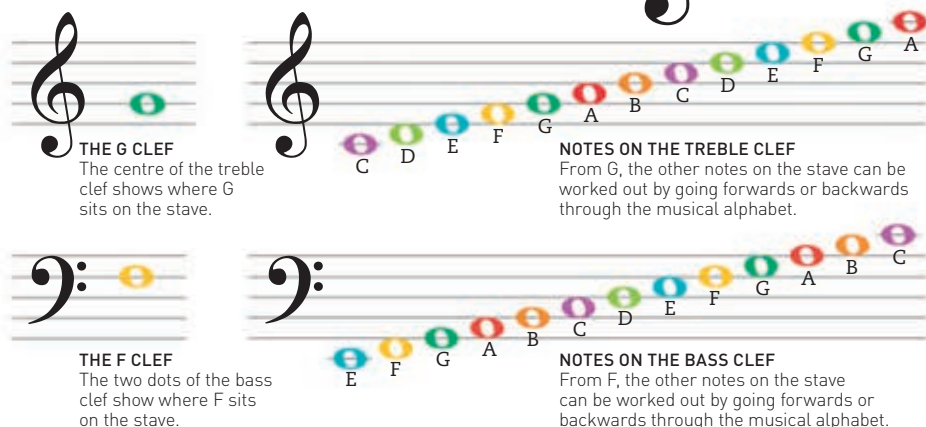
THE PIANO

With its unique layout, the piano is a useful instrument for learning music theory. The pattern of black and white keys shows the relationships between notes.

The white note between a pair of black notes grouped in twos is always D

CLEFS

A clef is normally written at the start – the left-hand end – of every staff on the page. It fixes the pitches of the lines and spaces. The two most common clefs are the treble (or G) clef, and the bass (or F) clef.



DOTTED NOTES

When a note is followed by a dot, it makes the note half as long again. The dotted crotchet below is $1\frac{1}{2}$ times longer than a crotchet, and the dotted minim is $1\frac{1}{2}$ times longer than a minim.

